INTRODUCTION

In November 2008, ten gunmen from Lashkar-e-Taiba rampaged through India's commercial capital, Mumbai, striking two luxury hotels, a café popular with foreign tourists, one of the country's busiest railway stations, and a Jewish community center. The death toll numbered 166 people in what was arguably the most successful terrorist spectacular since al-Qaeda launched its 9/11 operation.[1] The attacks garnered worldwide media attention and derailed a fragile peace process between India and Pakistan. One of the assailants was captured soon after the attacks began, but it took approximately sixty hours before Indian commandos were certain they had killed the last of the remaining terrorists. By the time the ordeal ended it appeared as though the world was facing a new menace.

Lashkar-e-Taiba means Army of the Pure.[2] By the time of the Mumbai attacks, it was one of the most powerful militant groups in South Asia and boasted transnational networks stretching across several continents. The group was generally agreed to be Pakistan's most powerful proxy against India, while experts debated whether it was also an al-Qaeda affiliate. Lashkar would surely reject the appellation, but after 9/11 it had become involved in the global jihad against America and its allies. Although it always had a maximalist agenda for jihad, Lashkar's priorities and approach were and are heavily influenced by Pakistan's rivalry with India. Thus, where al-Qaeda spoke of the 'Zionist-Crusader alliance,' Lashkar's forces were arrayed against a 'Hindu-Zionist-Crusader alliance.' The deliberate targeting of Westerners and Jews during the Mumbai attacks raised questions about the direction of the organization. Was this evidence that Lashkar was moving deeper into al-Qaeda's orbit, and perhaps on a trajectory to displace Osama bin Laden's network as the next major global jihadi threat? Or were the attacks simply the group's latest attempt to harm Pakistan's rival, India? To understand the calculus that informed Mumbai and why Lashkar suffered little fallout in Pakistan as a result of the attacks,